

8. The Views of My Friends

Realizing all this on the eve of the New Year, I was doomed to a joyless holiday season. What deeply grieves me the most is the realization that by the time I was born, my motherland had already been dead.

Someone who does not understand Chinese society might find it impossible to imagine my life. If I had simply been a heartless or oblivious person, it would have been fine. But in reality, the very reason I involuntarily ponder the past and future of my country during my free time—and even delve into the histories of other major nations to do so—is fundamentally because I harbor a profound affection for my country and my compatriots. I have always believed that our nation could be better, and that the Chinese people deserve to live happier lives.

For a mathematics student like myself, engaging in such reflections and writing down these words brings me no honor whatsoever; on the contrary, it may invite endless mockery and danger. Aside from a few close friends who have consistently expressed their trust in me, my family has never been sparing in their mockery and relentless belittlement. Yet, I persevered in this exploration. What sustained me was nothing more than my love for China (though, of course, the country and the government are two entirely different things) and my pursuit of truth.

But now I know that China has gone too far and too late down a dead end. Short of being utterly shattered and undergoing a complete reconstruction, where is the opportunity to turn back and return to the righteous path? One thousand four hundred years is such a vast expanse of time. When the 18th Dynasty of Egypt triumphantly expelled the Hyksos and expanded Egypt's borders to unprecedented lands, could anyone have imagined that 1,400 years later, even the death of the ancient Egyptian civilization would have entered its countdown? Living in this era, we are exactly like the citizens of Constantinople in the year 1400—what is there left to be done? It is precisely this irretrievable situation that fills me with sorrow.

After I returned to Xi'an, aside from H, who was the first to know, my friends A, F, S, G, and Z were also informed of this.

H was as open-minded and philosophical as ever. After all, this guy had long ceased to believe the government's official propaganda. Over the past two years, we had hiked together many times through the impoverished backwaters southwest of Beijing. Even without theoretical support, what we had seen with our own eyes and heard with our own ears had already given us a considerable understanding of China's current reality. Both H and I had already been somewhat mentally prepared when we learned the truth. It was merely because I had poured so much heart and soul into this endeavor that I inevitably felt depressed.

H expressed an attitude of "after us, the deluge." Ultimately, China's descent to this point is purely of its own making. Letting the doomed perish and the viable live on is simply the law of nature; why mourn for those destined to fall?

A appears somewhat nerdy but is actually exceptionally brilliant. He is also a mathematics major. When I told him about my discoveries, his first reaction was sheer astonishment. In A's own words, having spent these past few years in university—more than half of which were under pandemic lockdowns—and having surfed the internet, especially the global internet, for so long, how could one possibly not sense the rise and fall of the world around us? Only today, after being informed by me, did he finally fully understand the causes and consequences. His own intuitions had been

validated. Although, as a Chinese person, he certainly couldn't be happy about it, he simultaneously felt a kind of "so that's how it is" intellectual joy. I suppose this is a lifestyle unique to mathematics students!

F, S, and G are all my high school classmates. Their initial reactions were identical: after listening, they fell into silence, then stated they had no way to refute it and believed it to be true, followed by ceaseless sighing. F mentioned that he had just joined the Party. After learning the truth, he felt terrified and decided that from now on, he would remain an entirely "transparent person" (invisible), resolutely refusing to do anything harmful to the masses. Once the "world undergoes a drastic change" (天下有变), he would immediately detach himself and cut all ties, refusing to be a sinner of history.

S was much more action-oriented. After pondering for a month or two, he sought me out and said he had decided to emigrate to Canada as soon as possible and had already prepared a plan, quoting the old proverb: "A gentleman does not stand under a collapsing wall." As for G, we haven't met recently, so I am not entirely clear on his further thoughts.

Z is a classmate from Shandong whom I met at the Beijing Institute of Technology. He is steadfastly walking the path of officialdom—the career most coveted by Shandong natives. He joined the Party in his sophomore year, and by the time we parted ways in our senior year, he was already confirmed to become a *Xuandiao sheng* (选调生 / a fast-tracked civil servant). I still remember when we were chatting on the empty roads of the South Campus, and I told him all of this. After listening, Z said nothing, but his expression betrayed profound inner agony. After a long while, he finally asked: "In your deduction... is it possible that there are some errors?"

But after asking this, he fell silent again. I knew that Z's academic performance was quite excellent; at least up to the undergraduate level, he had received rigorous scientific training. Deep down, he knew very well that he could not find any logical contradictions. Before parting, he could only express the hope that I would observe the historical developmental paths of a few more countries to see if there was any room for revision. However, deep down, we both knew that this was practically impossible.

Nevertheless, when the Spring Festival concluded, the immediate necessity to tackle my graduation thesis and defense provided me with a temporary sense of relief. During that period, I simply didn't have much time to dwell on those agonizing realities.

8, 朋友们的看法

在新年来临之际意识到这些,我是注定不能过一个好年了。特别令我感到难过的是,当我出生的时候,我的祖国就已经死了。一个不了解中国社会的人可能无法想象我的生活,假设我本来也是个没心没肺的家伙也就罢了,但事实上我之所以会在空闲的时间不由自主地思考自己国家的过去和未来,甚至为此翻阅其他主要国家的历史,本身就是因为我对自己的国家和同胞很有感情,我总认为我们国家应该能够更好,中国的人民应该过得更幸福。对我一个数学系的学生而言,进行这些思考,写下这些文字,非但不能给我带来一点荣誉,反而可能带来无尽的嘲弄和危险,除了我的几个好友对我一直表示信赖以外,我的家人对我从来不吝嘲弄贬低之至。可是我还是把这种探索坚持下去,支持我的无非是对中国的热爱(当然国家和政府是两回事)和对真理的追求。但是现在我已经知道中国在一条死路上走得太远,太晚了,除了彻底粉碎之后进行重建,哪里还有掉头回到正道上的机会呢?一千四百年是多么漫长的时光,当埃及第18王朝意气风发地驱逐了希克索斯人,把埃及的版图扩大到前所未有的土地,能不能想到一千四百年之后即使连古埃及文明的死亡都已经进入倒计时了?我们生活在这个年代,就如同生活在一个公

元 1400 年的君士坦丁堡市民一样，还有什么事情可为呢？正是无可挽回的形势让我感到悲伤啊。当我回到西安之后，除了最早知道的 H，我的朋友中还有 A，F，S，G，Z 也被告知。

H 还是一如既往的豁达，毕竟这个家伙早都不相信政府的官方宣传，我们两年来一起在北京西南的穷乡僻壤徒步过多次，即使没有理论上的支撑，光是目所及耳所闻就已经对中国的现状有了不少了解。H 也好，我也罢，在知道真相的时候心里早就有了一定准备，只是因为我为之付出了不少心血，所以还是会情绪低落。H 表示管他洪水滔天，毕竟说到底，中国走到这一步是纯粹咎由自取，让该死的死，该活的活本来就是自然之理，何但哀将亡者为？A 这个人看起来呆呆的其实极为聪明，他也是数学专业，听到我告诉他自己的发现时第一反应是感到极为惊叹。用 A 自己的话来说，自己大学上了这么几年，还有一大半都是疫情防控中，互联网上特别是国际互联网上冲浪这么久，天下的成败怎么可能感受不到呢？今天得到我告知才终于完全了解前因后果，自己的直觉也得到了证明，虽然作为中国人肯定不会高兴，但是又有一种“原来如此”的喜悦。这大概就是数学人特有的生活方式吧！F，S 和 G 三个人都是我高中的同学，他们最初的表现是一致的，听完之后只有沉默，然后表示自己没办法反驳，也认为是对的，接着就是不住地叹气。F 表示自己刚刚入党，知道真相之后也感到害怕，决定以后只做透明人，坚决不干对人民群众有害的事，一旦“天下有变”就马上脱离与之撇清关系，不当这个历史罪人。

S 则更有行动力，他在思考了一两个月之后找到我说他决定尽快移民到加拿大去，并且已经做好了方案，表示君子不立危墙之下。至于 G 我们一直没有见面，所以不太清楚他的看法。Z 是我在北理工认识的山东同学，而且他确实确实走的是山东人最追捧的仕途，在大二就入了党，当我们大四分开的时候他已经确定要当选调生了。我现在还记得当时我们在南校区空旷的马路上聊天的时候，我告诉了他这些事情，Z 听完之后一言不发，但是神情显出了内心的痛苦，过了很久他才问道：你的推理里面…有没有可能出现一些错误？可他说完这句话又沉默了，我知道 Z 的成绩相当不错，至少到本科为止他是受过良好的科学训练的，他自己心里很清楚自己找不到什么矛盾。临走时只能表示，希望能再多观察几个国家的历史发展路径，看看到底有没有修正的地方，可是我们内心都知道这几乎已经不可能了。不过，当春节结束的时候，紧接着必须应对的毕业论文写作和毕业答辩在这种情况下反而让我暂时解脱，因为我在这段时间没有太多时间去思考那些让人痛苦的事了。